

**Graduate Writing Workshop
CSCI 6110
Fall 2026**

Instructor

Rebecca Morrison
ECOT 820
rebeccam@colorado.edu

Class details

Class meetings: Wednesday 1:15 – 2:30, ECCR 211, in person
Office hours: W 10:00 – 11:00

Materials

Clear and Simple as the Truth: Writing Class Prose (required)
Other various book chapters, articles, and blog posts will be provided on Canvas/Slack.
Students are encouraged to find hard copies of texts.

Course description

This is a course about writing and revising. Class activities include in-class exercises, peer-editing, and improv routines; watching videos by expert writers and screenwriters; and walks around campus with guided observations. These activities are designed to model writing as a conversation between author and reader—one in which the two participants view the subject clearly in front of them [9].

Course objectives

In this course, students will learn to:

- Draft and revise a scientific paper or proposal (of their choice)
- Peer-edit (multiple times) these works
- Apply the And-But-Therefore (ABT) technique [5] to write paper abstracts and introductions
- Add value to texts and align writing with expectations, as perceived by the reader
- Replace vague and bland language with nuance and specifics
- Polish existing CVs
- Tailor different works for the audience at hand
- Read about good, clear, strong technical writing, and also read lots of such examples

Course work and grading

There will approximately 15 in-class activities (one per class), graded for completion. The two lowest grades will be dropped. Make-ups allowed; see below. Grades are determined based on attendance (30%) and participation (70%) in the various writing and editing exercises.

Make-ups: To get credit for an in-class exercise, please do the following:

1. Find a partner (from class, or outside of it).
2. Complete the activity. Ask a classmate for what to do.
3. Write up a short report (≤ 1 page), including:
 - Names of participants
 - What you did
 - What you learned
 - What stood out to you or surprised you during the activity
 - How you will incorporate any of this into your own writing.
4. Turn this in within a week of missed class.

Note about attendance: Since this class is hands-on and the group aspect is important, attendance is recorded and will not be excused for any reason. However, sometimes it is impossible to attend for good reasons. The grading scheme above should allow for a few absences without any impact on expected grade. If you feel that the attendance policy is too strict, please come talk to me at any point during the semester and we can work something out.

References

- [1] A. Alda. *If I Understood You, Would I Have this Look on my Face?: My Adventures in the Art and Science of Relating and Communicating*. Random House Trade Paperbacks, 2018.
- [2] W. Germano. *On Revision: The Only Writing that Counts*. University of Chicago Press, 2021.
- [3] B. Greene. Welcome to the Multiverse. *Newsweek*, May, 21:2012, 2012.
- [4] A. Lamott. Shitty first drafts. *Writing About Writing: A College Reader*, pages 527–531, 1994.
- [5] R. Olson. *Houston, We Have a Narrative*. University of Chicago Press, 2021.
- [6] S. Pinker. Why academics stink at writing. *The Chronicle of Higher Education*, 61(5), 2014.
- [7] V. Savage and P. Yeh. Novelist Cormac McCarthy's tips on how to write a great science paper. *Nature*, 574(7777):441–443, 2019.
- [8] H. Sword. *Stylish Academic Writing*. Harvard University Press, 2011.
- [9] F.-N. Thomas and M. Turner. *Clear and Simple as the Truth: Writing Classic Prose*. Princeton University Press, 2011.